



Role model: Manpreet Singh dons the iconic number seven, a nod to Portuguese great Cristiano Ronaldo, whose fitness, skill, and tireless work ethic at 40 continue to inspire him. REUTERS

second Indian after Dilip Tirkey to play 400 international matches. He received a guard of honour and a special jersey from the Australian team.

Yet milestones leave him unfazed. "These individual numbers don't excite me. Make no mistake, I'm proud to represent my country on the international stage, but for me, what I'm doing to make my team win matters the most."

A veteran of four Olympics, Manpreet has witnessed Indian hockey's transformation over the last decade and a half — and his own life has evolved alongside it. "Zameen aasman ka fark hain (There's a world of difference). Hockey has become faster. Several rule changes, especially the self-start rule, have increased the pace. It has become more and more tactical," he says.

Asked how the midfielder's role has evolved, he is direct. "Kaafi change hua hain (It has changed a lot). Midfield is the bridge between attack and defence, so we have to participate in both. It demands versatility, athleticism, and tactical intelligence," he explains.

Leading into the Asia Cup, the

Khel Ratna awardee reflected on the mental steel athletes need. "Agar aapke andar belief hain, to aap kuch bhi kar sakte hain (if you believe in yourself, you can achieve anything)." He says the team focuses on the future: "As a collective, we talk about 'What's next?' Whatever has happened in the past cannot be changed, but we can make things better for each other in the future."

Speaking about the personal sacrifices of international hockey, Manpreet becomes emotional. "It's very tough. I've two daughters; one is three, and the other is just three months old. I don't get to spend a lot of time with them. But whenever my elder daughter comes to see me play, it gives me extra motivation to perform. I hope she will be proud of my achievements as a player."

His journey began in Mithapur, a small village in Jalandhar, Punjab, with a rich hockey history. Idolising local hero Pargat Singh, he honed his craft and rose to become a mainstay of the national team. Despite his accolades, he isn't dwelling on legacy. "Abhi tohh khelna hain, aur bhi jeetna hain (I still have to play and win a lot more titles)."

Rapid fire



If you weren't a hockey player, what would you be?

I would probably be a driver somewhere in a foreign country.

Last movie you watched?

Housefull 5.

If you could get a superpower for a day, what would it be? And what would you do with it?

I would like to have the speed of Flash. If I have that power, I can always go back home every day from anywhere while continuing my career.

What is your favourite cheat meal?

Either pizza or burger.

Who is your favourite singer?

It depends on my mood and my environment. Before a match, I get pumped up with the energetic beats of Diljit Dosanjh and Sidhu Moose Wala. But when I'm alone and relaxing in my room, I prefer the soulful melodies of Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan, Jaani, and B. Praak.

An outright win in regulation time or a win through a penalty shootout?

Shootout.

Which team-mate can help you escape from a deserted island?

I won't choose anyone. None of them have any survival skills. Their presence would likely hinder my chances of survival (laughs).

A secret talent you have?

I'm good at calming babies. I have a lot of experience in this department now.

Who's the GOAT of hockey?

Dhyan Chand is the greatest. In the modern era, I would say Moritz Fürste. He is my idol.